



Schizophrenia

Schizophrenia is a serious mental disorder associated with brain functioning that can significantly affect the way a person perceives and evaluates reality. The disorder affects not only thoughts but also emotions, behavior, attention, memory, problem-solving abilities, and relationships with other people. It generally becomes apparent in late adolescence, the twenties, and early adulthood. However, schizophrenia does not follow a single course: in some individuals, symptoms may increase and decrease in episodes, whereas in others, more persistent difficulties may develop over time.

One of the most prominent features of schizophrenia is that a person's connection with reality may become disrupted. For example, a person may hear voices that are not actually present or may see, feel, or smell things that do not exist. This is referred to as a hallucination. In a delusion, another symptom, a person may hold a particular belief with firm conviction even when there is evidence demonstrating otherwise. In addition, thoughts may become disorganized, making speech difficult to understand. Marked disorganization of behavior or excessive increase or slowing of a person's movements may also occur.

However, considering schizophrenia as consisting only of these symptoms would be incomplete. The disorder also includes negative and cognitive symptoms, which may be less noticeable but can have serious effects on a person's daily functioning. A person may have difficulty speaking, expressing emotions, or taking an interest in things they previously enjoyed, and may withdraw from other people. In addition, difficulties may arise in cognitive abilities such as attention, working memory, learning, problem-solving, information processing, and the evaluation of social situations. These difficulties can have significant consequences in areas of daily life such as education, employment, and social relationships.

Research indicates that schizophrenia does not have a single cause. While genetic characteristics play an important role, environmental factors are also thought to contribute to the risk of developing the disorder. Research on brain development suggests that the development and maturation of the brain may occur differently in schizophrenia. In particular, changes in the connections between nerve cells that occur during brain development in childhood and adolescence are thought to be associated with the disorder. Genetic and environmental factors appear to play a role together with these processes.

Certain chemical systems involved in communication within the brain are also important in schizophrenia. In particular, abnormalities in the dopamine and glutamate systems have been extensively considered. While certain imbalances in dopamine are associated particularly with psychotic symptoms such as delusions and hallucinations,

abnormalities in the glutamate system are thought to play an important role in cognitive difficulties. Therefore, schizophrenia is considered not merely a problem involving thoughts, but rather a complex disorder in which different functions of the brain are affected together.

Antipsychotic medications have an important place in the treatment of schizophrenia. These medications can help reduce psychotic symptoms, in particular. In addition, approaches such as psychoeducation, family support, cognitive-behavioral therapy, and psychosocial rehabilitation are also important components of treatment. It is particularly important to support the individual in developing daily living skills, maintaining social functioning, and establishing the most independent life possible. Nevertheless, cognitive symptoms may not completely resolve despite treatment, and research into new treatment approaches for this area is ongoing.

Although schizophrenia is a serious disorder, it does not follow the same course in every individual. According to sources, at least one-third of people living with schizophrenia may experience complete recovery of symptoms. Therefore, it would not be appropriate to evaluate the disorder solely on the basis of its most severe manifestations. Early and consistent treatment, social support, and the individual's

active participation in the treatment process are important.

Finally, schizophrenia can affect not only the person living with the disorder but also their family and social environment. Stigma and discrimination related to the disorder may further make it difficult for the individual to participate in society. Therefore, an important part of understanding schizophrenia is to view the person living with the disorder not merely through their symptoms, but as a human being who needs treatment, support, and the ability to maintain their life.

References:

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